

Here he was, a boy, not quite 6 or 7. Somewhere in the middle. He boarded the plane with his mother, a lady he had only met twice before. The lady was somewhere the age of 26. In the lady's hands was the boy's sister, one of two. She had just turned 1.

The boy and his mother took their seats, and the sister remained in the lady's arms. The flight attendant walked over to the boy and said something. It was gibberish and the boy understood nothing. His mother nodded and smiled politely. The flight attendant reached down the side of the boy's left leg and pulled out a device. The boy immediately recognized what it was, and lost himself to it.

Time passed and the mother and her daughter fell asleep. The boy did not. The cabin of the airplane had its lights dimmed, and he could see his own reflection on the surface of the device. His reflection told him

he was sad. He was sad to leave his grandparents. They had taken care of him for the better of 6 or 7 years. No, there was no reason to be sad; he knew he would be back in their care. His mother had told him he was just going to some country to pick up an iPad and will come right back and return him to the grandparents.

He was wrong. The boy will not see his grandparents on home soil for at least another 10 years. Nor will he breathe the same air from the land that he was born in. The friends he had made in kindergarten will come by his grandparents' apartment, asking where he was, and leave with the same answer day after day.

Looking back at the boy's life, I do not know what was the right decision. However, I know if the same boy knew what awaited him for the next 6 years, he would have

fought tooth and nail to be left with his grandparents.

As he touched down in some strange new country, his father, a man he had never seen before, greeted him. The father put his arm around the boy, who burst into tears. He wanted his grandparents, but circumstances will prevent it for the foreseeable future. The father was happy, for he had finally held his son for the first time ever.

The family drove home, and the mother went straight to making dinner. Some sort of soup noodles was on the menu. The father gave the comfiest chair in the house for the boy to sit on. The boy himself had recovered from missing his grandparents, and wandered around the house, curious to this new environment he was in. The family had a housekeeper, and she was hanging up the laundry. She gave a kind smile to the boy and

said something to him. The boy never understood what she said, and never replied in any way.

After dinner, the housekeeper left, and it was time for bed. The boy slept in his own bed, whilst his sister, mother, and father slept in another. When he woke up, his father was gone. Off to work. The mother and the boy's sister were with him. The boy was quite proud of himself, for he did not cry through the night, as he was known to do so when spending the night somewhere that was not his grandparents' apartment.

The three ate breakfast, and the mother took the boy and his sister out to go sightseeing. The boy did not care. He did not understand what was so interesting that he saw. Rivers, beaches, parks, he had seen them all before. The only thing that piqued his interest was the food. He would soon later

learn that one of his favourite foods in this new country was called a “Potato Top Pie”.

Days passed, and the boy started getting used to the new country. He still could not understand a single thing people would say to him though. Additionally, the boy was starting primary school in a few weeks. He had to learn a new language, or else he would not be able to get anywhere in his new school.

And so, it began. In order to make sure his son knew some words in English and how to introduce himself, the father devised a demanding, if not cruel, regime. The boy was subjected to repeating the same word in a list verbally 10 times. The list contained 200 basic English words, such as “Hello”, “Hi”, “Good”, “Morning”, “Thanks”, and so on. He would do this before and after breakfast. Each word eventually became so ingrained in the boy’s

mind, tongue, and throat, that he would unconsciously tense up each time he spoke it, even 3 years later when he was a fluent speaker of the language.

After lunch, the boy was demanded by his father to write the list of words out, 5 times. Each word had to be written with precision, not scribbles. If the father did not like the boy's handwriting, he would demand the boy to re-write the word.

It was only after dinner that the boy had a break. This schedule was repeated for two weeks. If the boy complained or started crying out of frustration, the father hit him. The father physically abused his own son, and forced him to keep going with the demanding schedule.

The mother supported the father fully. Even when her own son had blood pouring out of his nose like a faucet, or the right side

of his face was swollen like a balloon, the mother did not step in to stop the father. She even contributed to the abuse, more with her tongue than her hands. With each slap, punch, kick, scold, the boy's heart greyed with coldness. He became scared and mad of the figures that he was meant to love, meant to look up to. But no, this life was not going to be an easy one for him.

The housekeeper - I wish I could say stepped in and stopped the madness - turned a blind eye to such abuse. In the future, when the physical abuse lessened significantly to a point where it almost became 0, the boy would wonder what made the housekeeper comfortable around such violence.

All adults were once disobedient children, and that fact was proven when the boy started at his primary school. He was given a

book to take home to read out loud with his parents, and he struggled greatly. Several words in the book were not in the list that his father gave him. The boy's father would say out loud one word and the boy successfully repeated it after him. However, the two would go over the entire book, and the boy could not memorize the pronunciation of upwards of 100 words in one sitting.

Of course the father became frustrated. Of course the only way he could resolve such frustration was to use physical abuse. Which he did. Books became weapons to the boy. The covers of books would become deeply intimate with the face of the boy, as they were repeatedly smacked across them.

The housekeeper tried helping the boy out by teaching him the words - perhaps the only time she tried intervening - but the father was watching, and he even grew frustrated



just at the sight of his boy not being able to memorize all the words.

Blood from the boy's nose would stain the pages of the book, and the schoolteachers would become concerned for the boy's home life. The boy told them in broken English what happened at home (he thought there was nothing wrong with it) and the school's principal went to the boy's house to have a talk with the parents. This was the first time the boy told someone how his home life was.

It should come to no surprise that the boy's parents disobeyed the principal. Day after day, the same event would happen once the boy returned from school. Home, a place where every child takes solace in, became the complete opposite for the boy.

Due to the adults' at home having a disappointing ability in teaching, the school took note of the lack of progress of speaking

in the boy, and assigned a specialized teacher to teach him English. That teacher was the school's librarian, Nina.

The boy and Nina will form a tight bond, something that will last all the way to the boy's adulthood, and beyond. In contrast to the style of teaching at home, Nina's was soft and patient, and the boy loved it. He learned more in one session with Nina than he had with the adults at home for two weeks. Nina also introduced one of the boy's favourite picture books: Mechanical Harry. This book would ignite a fire in the boy, a fire that burned deeply for problem solving and using it to ease burdens of everyday life. Nina showed to the boy that books were not to be used as weapons, but as sources that are rich in knowledge, fuel for creativity, and the worlds that were created from a person's imagination.

In Nina's care, the boy's brain began to blossom in terms of creativity and imagination. The boy spent all his free time in the library, either being taught by Nina in English, or reading books that grabbed his attention.